

MEI LAN-FANG, 67, STAGE ACTOR, DIES

**Top Chinese Star Was Noted
as Female Impersonator**

PEIPING, Aug. 8 (Reuters)
—Mei Lan-fang, China's leading stage artist, died here today of a heart ailment. He was 67 years old.

His Art Transcended Ideology

Although he worked in an ancient, formalized dramatic tradition only dimly intelligible to outsiders, Mei Lan-fang's artistry transcended ideologies and cultural frontiers. He was one of the most famous and best-paid actors of all time.

His delicate mastery of the conventionalized tan, or female, roles in a repertory of more than 400 musical plays earned him \$750,000 in 1927. He received up to \$4,000 for half-hour private performances of singing and dancing in the Chinese classical tradition.

He received the highest honors from the last of the Manchu Emperors, Hsuan-tung (also known as Henry Pu-yi). And a few days before his death Premier Chou En-lai, who played tan roles as a youth, visited his hospital bedside.

Not only did Mei's fifty-five-year career survive two Chinese revolutions and the Japanese invasion but his acting won acclaim in the alien cultures of the United States and Europe as well.

Praised by Critic Here

After the opening of Mei's triumphant tour of this country in 1930, Brooks Atkinson, then drama critic of The New York Times, wrote:

"It is, in fact, an arrested form of classical drama with virtually no striving after illusion and hardly a suggestion of realism. But it is as beautiful as an old Chinese vase or tapestry. If you can purge yourself of the sophomoric illusion that it is funny, merely because it is different, you can begin to appreciate something of exquisite loveliness in pantomime and costume, and you may feel yourself vaguely in contact, not with the sensation of the moment, but with the strange ripeness of centuries."

Mei became a national hero by resolutely refusing to perform his demure dances and maidenly falsetto songs for the Japanese, who occupied China from 1937 to 1943. His final answer to Japanese importunity and threats was to grow a mustache.

The Japanese retaliated by announcing his death from poisoning in August, 1943. The Times obituary on Aug. 11, 1943, noted that the report was unconfirmed. It said:

"As a box-office 'draw' he had no equal in the world."

Mei was born in Peiping into a family already famous for its actors. His grandfather, Ch'iao-ling, was a renowned impersonator of female roles, which until recent decades were traditionally required to be performed by men. His paternal uncle, Yu-ti'en, one of China's foremost musicians, took charge of Mei's early training.

The actor made his professional debut in 1905. As his fame spread throughout the Orient, he was accorded the title of "Foremost of the Peach Orchard," meaning that he was without a peer as an actor in China.

Toured in Japan

Mei's first foreign tours were to Japan in 1917 and 1923. By petition of 270,000 admirers he received the title of "Great King of Actors."

He brought a troupe of twenty-two actors with ninety-two trunks containing 1,000 costumes to the United States in 1930. His scheduled two-week run here in 1930 was such a success that it was extended to five weeks. He performed also in Chicago and San Francisco.

During his eight years of self-imposed retirement under the Japanese occupation, Mei pursued his studies of European drama as well as the Chinese classics. He also painted. He supported himself by selling parts of his collection of costumes and ancient stage manuscripts.

Mei emerged from retirement after World War II. When the Communists established their rule in 1949 they heaped honors upon him and appointed him to high theatrical and scholarly positions. He became a deputy of the National People's Congress (Parliament) in 1955, but he did not join the Communist party until 1959.

He married Meng Hsiao-tung, a well-known actress. They had three sons and a daughter.



Hsinhua News Agency
Mei Lan-fang